Real good luck for the game, away to local rivals Atlético Madrid of all people. It would go down to the wire in La Liga. Real had to win to have a chance of beating Real Sociedad to the title. Atlético was a huge game: I felt a bit embarrassed that all the transfer speculation might be distracting from it. Before I made any kind of decision, though, I felt like I needed to talk to Senor Perez. He wanted to know where we were with everything.

'At the moment, I'm still a Manchester United player and until I settle things at this end, it's not right for me to talk about moving to Real.'

Real had made their contact. And United were prepared to talk. He's a remarkable man, Senor Perez. He's powerful but there's nothing loud about him. He's inspiring to listen to. He was that day, too, even through a translator:

'I understand. All I want to say to you now, David, is that if you come to Madrid you won't ever regret it. We don't want you here for the publicity or to sell shirts. I think you are one of the best players in the world and we believe you can make us a better team.'

By the time I hung up, I knew what David Beckham, the soccer player, needed to do next. There was still a massive family decision to be made, though, and after the barbecue we talked about it for hours. Tony was there for a while. He talked to Mum and then, later, spoke to Dad on the phone. He explained the situation to Victoria's mum and dad as well. Then he said to us:

'You know the options. Staying at United, moving to Madrid, moving to one of the other clubs that are interested in you. You don't need to think about the details, contracts, money, anything else. You and Victoria need to just decide what would be best for you as a family. Once you do, we'll try and make it happen.'

Over the course of the evening, things that had seemed scary when we'd first thought about them—leaving England, settling in a new country, learning a new language—started to seem more like an opportunity for all of us. I was so excited about the idea of Madrid, the soccer club, that it was easier for me to get excited about Madrid, the city, and Madrid, the way of life, as well. Victoria didn't have that to push her towards the move but she was brave enough, and we were honest enough with each other, to recognize that it was the right thing to do. And that it was something that, if we were together, could be something great for all of us. She'd lived through the last year with me and knew how unhappy I'd been as things went wrong in Manchester. She understood the situation perfectly.